

SI-MI: Social Identity Matters in Mentoring

Session 6: From Deficit- to Asset-Based Mentoring

Guiding question: How can mentors shift from deficit-based assumptions to recognizing and building on the strengths and assets mentees bring?

Overview: This session focuses on shifting from deficit-based assumptions to asset-based mentoring approaches, particularly when working with students of color. Participants will explore how mentors can better recognize strengths, forms of knowledge, and sources of resilience that may be overlooked in academic settings. The session emphasizes mentoring practices that affirm and build on what mentees already bring.

Objectives:

- Differentiate deficit-based and asset-based approaches to mentoring.
- Recognize strengths and forms of cultural wealth that mentees bring to academic environments.
- Consider how an asset-based perspective can reshape mentoring practice.

Before the Session: Complete the assigned readings and reflection before the session. Be prepared to think about how mentors can move beyond deficit narratives and more intentionally recognize, affirm, and support the assets of students of color.

- **Read:** [From Deficits to Possibilities](#) by Beronda L. Montgomery
- **Read:** [Whose Culture has Capital?](#) By Tara J. Yosso
 - Starting at P. 77 (I. Aspirational Capital) and ending on P.81 before the Discussion section
- **Reflect:**
 - How does the analogy of the relationship between humans and plants shift or deepen your understanding of what it means to support students?
 - What strengths or assets can be observed in students of color that may be overlooked when viewed through a deficit lens?

What to Expect in the Live Session: The live session will include reflection, group discussion, and collaborative application of strengths-based mentoring ideas. Participants should expect to explore broad examples, connect the readings to mentoring practice, and consider concrete ways to support mentees through an asset-based lens.

Takeaways:

- Deficit-based thinking limits how mentors perceive and support mentees.
- Asset-based mentoring highlights strengths, resilience, and forms of cultural wealth.
- Mentors can actively reframe narratives to focus on capability rather than lack.